

dream—of attending a nursing course in the University of Virginia. Shivli Patel, 33, a Vadodara-based software programmer, is another example of the change sweeping through India. There was a time when she could barely pass on written messages in broken English. Ten weeks later, she could easily write long letters and short essays. A few weeks ago, she was able to impress the consultant who had been trying to get her an H1 visa to the US. "My entire personality has changed. I feel light and confident when it comes to English," she says.

This urge to learn English isn't restricted to those aspiring to travel abroad. Abhay Shah, 44, is a garment exporter who runs the third largest children's garment manufacturing company in Ahmedabad with a turnover of Rs 20 crore. A product of a Gujarati-medium school, English had always been a handicap for him especially since he had to travel abroad for business. He could then manage only a few sentences in broken English. But now he speaks with ease. The importance of English in their lives can be gauged from Shah's clientele, which comes from Gujarat villages and Rajasthan's small towns, often hiring flats or renting hostel rooms. From lecturers to English-medium school students who think they need to hone their English language skills, the institute has trained nearly 12,000 candidates in over two decades.

It's a complete course and designed in a manner that covers English reading, writing, speaking, listening and vocabulary building with the help of audio-visual presentations and self-visualisation. Shah, who did her schooling in Gujarati but went on to do her post-graduation in English Literature from Georgia University in the US, is her own best advertisement. "There is little doubt that learning English has now become part of one's personality development as well as a career requirement in India," she says. As India becomes part of the international community, its global language becomes a necessary qualification for entry.



Ringside voyeurism

Viewer obsession with stars and the celebrity desperation for instant fame, blend together to form a new potent kind of reality

■ By Akhila Krishnamurthy

For the past two weeks, Uma Riyaz Khan, a Chennai-based actor and her actor-partner Prithveeraj, have been matching steps with each other to master the perfect dance routine. As Khan turns on the engine of her car, the stereo roars with the '80s Tamil film hit, *Oru Nayakan*. She tactically manoeuvres her way through Chennai's chaotic traffic, rehearsing the dance steps in her mind. Khan is up for the *Jodi No. 1* show, a dance competition on Star Vijay where Chennai's celebrities tango to the top.

The sense of energy is palpable at the Raak Academy of Dance, as is the tension. Khan and Prithveeraj are being made to practise their steps by choreographer Yuvraj. He wants them to reproduce the exact flavour of the song they are going to perform and doesn't let up till they are in perfect rhythm. The practice goes on for six hours, but neither star is complaining. The show, launched last October, was the first time the stars were seen beyond their on-screen personas, and viewers have dug in with delight, rel-

ishing the departure from the staid world of celebrity coverage and allowing viewers full freedom to be voyeurs. Although it's all about the experience and enjoyment for Khan, Prithveeraj is keeping his fingers crossed. A win could boost his film career and the prize money of Rs 10 lakh can't be sniffed at.

"DANCING IS MY PASSION AND I'M HERE TO PERFORM FOR MY VIEWERS ACROSS THE WORLD."

UMA RIYAZ KHAN

STAR VIJAY

FOR REALITY'S SAKE: Khan (standing, extreme left), Prithveeraj (standing, extreme right)

